

Getting to the Table Was the Easy Part

Filling a room with the right people is a win. Getting them to work together is something else.

BY KEN MYERS

Getting people together is hard, but on June 5th, we did it: grassroots organizers and funders, startups and local government, all in one room at the Philadelphia Food Summit. I've learned something harder over the years, though. A full table and a functioning table aren't the same thing. You can gather all the right people in the city and still see nothing happen.

I've spent years gathering the people who care into the same room and watching what happens. More often than I'd like to admit, they arrive ready to collaborate, but quietly protect everything they walked in with. Their pride. The idea they're afraid someone will take. The credit that went to the bigger brand last time. The promise that never became a paycheck. The lived experience of the problem that the person across from them doesn't share. None of it gets named. So it settles, and real exchange dies in the silence.

This is never a failure of commitment. It's a failure of how we show up.

The hardest work at any table is internal. Getting to the table is logistics. What you do once you're there is a choice, and it's the choice that decides if anything gets built. Three shifts separate the rooms that work from the rooms that only look like they're working.

The first is to honor the difference. Assume the person across from you sees the problem differently than you do, because they do. The farmer, the pastor, the caseworker, the person who has actually stood in a meal line. Each carries a different piece of the same crisis. Honoring that means asking before telling, and listening to learn the shape of someone's work before deciding how it fits with yours. Most efforts skip this. They name the mission, rush to solutions, and wonder why the plan breaks under the first real pressure.

The second is to extend grace. Grace is not sentiment. It's a decision you make before you sit down. When the person across the table gets defensive, you stay steady and remember they're carrying something. When someone guards their approach harder than they should, you consider what's been taken from them before. Grace gives people space to lower their walls. Without it, you get a room that's present in body but sealed off in every way that matters.

The third is humility. It begins with an honest admission: no one at the table can fix this alone. Once you accept that, the work each person offers becomes the thing worth protecting. When a well-resourced institution hears an idea born in a basement with no budget, it faces a choice: take it and scale it under a new name, or come alongside the person who built it. Not in front of them. Not in place of them. Together. That's trust, built as a structure.

The summit didn't solve hunger on June 5th. It was never going to.

What it did was set a table with the right people around it. Whether that becomes anything depends entirely on whether we carry these shifts out the door. Into the next meeting, the next partnership, the next room full of complicated people trying to solve problems too big for any one of them.

Maintain them, and the table holds. Leave them, and the table breaks. Then we're strangers stuck in the same fight again, performing connection, wondering why it's always this hard.

I've sat at both kinds of tables. The difference was never the people. It was what we were willing to do once we sat down.

Ken Myers is co-founder of M Movement, a Philadelphia nonprofit that connects mission-driven organizations through collective action and a shared commitment to showing up fully for one another.

The 2026 Philadelphia Food Summit took place Friday, June 5, at Temple University's Howard Gittis Student Center. Learn more at phillyfoodsummit.org, and support the ongoing work at [the summit's donation page](#).